Forget Not All His Benefits

Praise begins when we deliberately remember what God has done for us and who he is.

Main passage	Psalm 103:1-13 (KJV)
Topic	Praise
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Stir up your soul to praise	7 min
Teaching point 2: Count his benefits	7 min
Teaching point 3: Praise God for who he is	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Why do we forget good things so easily and remember hurts so well?" Let the class discuss for a minute. Then point out that David talks to himself at the start of this psalm. He tells his own soul to praise and not to forget. Praise is not always a feeling that comes over us; sometimes it is a choice we make.

Scripture (3 min)

Psalm 103:1-13

[1] A Psalm of David. Bless the LORD, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless his holy name. [2] Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits: [3] Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases; [4] Who redeemeth thy life from destruction; who crowneth thee with lovingkindness and tender mercies; [5] Who satisfieth thy mouth with good things; so that thy youth is renewed like the eagle's. [6] The LORD executeth righteousness and judgment for all that are oppressed. [7] He made known his ways unto Moses, his acts unto the children of Israel. [8] The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and plenteous in mercy. [9] He will not always chide: neither will he keep his anger for ever. [10] He hath not dealt with us after our sins; nor rewarded us according to our iniquities. [11] For as the heaven is high above the earth, so great is

his mercy toward them that fear him. [12] As far as the east is from the west, so far hath he removed our transgressions from us. [13] Like as a father pitieth his children, so the LORD pitieth them that fear him.

Read the passage aloud slowly. Consider having the whole class read verses 1-2 together as an opening call to worship.

Background (5 min)

Psalm 103 is titled "A Psalm of David." It is one of the best-loved psalms of praise and has been sung in churches for centuries, including in the hymn "Praise, My Soul, the King of Heaven." Matthew Henry says it "calls more for devotion than exposition."

The psalm moves outward. David begins with his own soul and the benefits he personally has received (vv. 1-5). Then he praises God's dealings with his people (vv. 6-13). At the end (vv. 19-22, beyond today's reading) he calls on angels and all creation to join in.

> *"This psalm calls more for devotion than exposition; it is a most excellent psalm of praise, and of general use."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Psalm 103:1-22

Teaching point 1: Stir up your soul to praise (7 min)

"Bless the LORD, O my soul" (v. 1). David speaks to himself. Praise involves "all that is within me": mind, heart and will. Sometimes we must remind ourselves to praise. Matthew Henry says that it is no foolishness to talk to yourself in this way when you are urging your own soul toward what is good.

Supporting verses

Psalm 103:1-2: A Psalm of David. Bless the LORD, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless his holy name. Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits:

Psalm 42:5: Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why art thou disquieted in me? hope thou in God: for I shall yet praise him for the help of his countenance.

Psalm 146:1-2: Praise ye the LORD. Praise the LORD, O my soul. While I live will I praise the LORD: I will sing praises unto my God while I have any being.

> *"David is here communing with his own heart, and he is no fool that thus talks to himself and excites his own soul to that which is good."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Psalm 103:1-5

Handout blanks (answers)

Bless the LORD, O my **soul**.

Praise often begins as a **choice**, not a feeling.

Teaching point 2: Count his benefits (7 min)

"Forget not all his benefits" (v. 2). David then names them: forgiveness, healing, redemption, loving-kindness, satisfaction, renewed strength (vv. 3-5). Adam Clarke says we should call them to mind and name the chief ones one by one. General thankfulness quickly fades. Specific remembering produces praise.

Supporting verses

Psalm 103:2-5: Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits: Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases; Who redeemeth thy life from destruction; who crowneth thee with lovingkindness and tender mercies; Who satisfieth thy mouth with good things; so that thy youth is renewed like the eagle's.

Psalm 116:12: What shall I render unto the LORD for all his benefits toward me?

Lamentations 3:22-23: It is of the LORD's mercies that we are not consumed, because his compassions fail not. They are new every morning: great is thy faithfulness.

> *"Call them into recollection; particularize the chief of them"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 103:2

> *"redeemeth--Cost is implied."*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Psalm 103:4

Handout blanks (answers)

Forget not all his **benefits**.

Praise grows when we remember **specifically** what God has done.

Teacher note: Verse 3, "who healeth all thy diseases," may raise questions from those who are ill or have lost loved ones. Christians agree that every healing, by medicine or by answered prayer, is God's gift and that final, complete healing comes in the resurrection. Christians differ on what to expect of miraculous healing today; that question belongs to a separate lesson.

Teaching point 3: Praise God for who he is (7 min)

In verses 8-13 David moves from what God has done to what God is like: merciful, gracious, slow to anger, plenteous in mercy. God does not deal with us as our sins deserve. He removes our sins as far as the east is from the west, and he pities his children as a father does. The deepest praise is not only "thank you for" but "you are."

Supporting verses

Psalm 103:8-13 (read from the Bible)

Exodus 34:6-7: And the LORD passed by before him, and proclaimed, The LORD, The LORD God, merciful and gracious, longsuffering, and abundant in goodness and truth, Keeping mercy for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, and that will by no means clear the guilty; visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children, and upon the children's children, unto the third and to the fourth generation.

Micah 7:18-19: Who is a God like unto thee, that pardoneth iniquity, and passeth by the transgression of the remnant of his heritage? he retaineth not his anger for ever, because he delighteth in mercy. He will turn again, he will have compassion upon us; he will subdue our iniquities; and thou wilt cast all their sins into the depths of the sea.

> *"He has never apportioned our punishment to our sins, nor has he regulated the exercise of his mercy by our merits."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 103:10

> *"God's benevolence implies no merit."*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Psalm 103:8-10

Handout blanks (answers)

The LORD is merciful and **gracious**.

As far as the east is from the **west**, so far hath he removed our transgressions.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think David has to tell his own soul to praise?

Our hearts drift, forget and grow dull; praise sometimes begins as an act of the will.

2. Which of the benefits in verses 3-5 means most to you right now, and why?

Answers will vary.

3. What does "as far as the east is from the west" tell us about God's forgiveness?

It is complete and final; east and west never meet, so forgiven sin is never brought back against us.

4. How is praising God for who he is different from thanking him for what he has done?

Thanks responds to gifts; praise delights in the Giver himself, and continues even when circumstances are hard.

Application (3 min)

This week, keep a "benefits list." Each evening, write down three specific things God has done for you that day. On Sunday, read your list and pray Psalm 103:1-2 aloud.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Bless the Lord, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless his holy name. Lord, forgive us for forgetting your benefits. Thank you for forgiving our sins, redeeming our lives and crowning us with loving-kindness. You

are merciful and gracious, slow to anger and plenteous in mercy. We praise you, through Jesus Christ our Lord, Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Psalm 103:1-22

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Psalm 103:1-5

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 103:2

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Psalm 103:4

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 103:10

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Psalm 103:8-10

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